

doc-legalism-denial

Affirms · Soteriology › Denied Errors · doctrine · outside_majority_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

Adding human rules to God's commands as conditions of acceptance, fellowship, or sanctification — and treating obedience as the ground rather than the fruit of grace — distorts the gospel.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical demonstration that adding human rules or law-works to the gospel as conditions of acceptance, fellowship, or sanctification distorts the gospel and corrupts grace. The Pauline polemic is built on a tight semantic cluster: ἔργα νόμου *erga nomou* G2041 + G3551 ('works of the law', Rom 3:20, 28; Gal 2:16 (3x); 3:2, 5, 10), δικαιώω *dikaioō* G1344 ('justify', courtroom verdict) consistently negated when paired with *ex ergōn nomou*, and χάρις *charis* G5485 ('grace') framed as the antithesis of *ergon-merit*. Gal 2:16 stacks three uses of *dikaioō* (present passive indicative, aorist passive subjunctive, future passive indicative) in one verse with the explicit contrast *ou ex ergōn nomou ean mē dia pisteōs Christou Iēsou* ('not out of works of law except through faith of Christ Jesus'). Gal 2:21 closes the unit: *ouk athetō tēn charin tou theou; ei gar dia nomou dikaiosynē, ara Christos dōrean apethanen* ('I do not nullify the grace of God; for if righteousness is through law, then Christ died for nothing'). Gal 5:1-6 carries the verdict to its sharpest edge: *katēgēthēte apo Christou hoitines en nomō dikaiousthe, tēs charitōs exepesate* G1601 aorist active indicative 2p ('you were severed from Christ, you who would be justified by the law; you have fallen out of grace'). The aorist-active *exepesate* marks a completed-past act of falling-out, the same root used for a flower falling from its stem. Gal 1:6-9 frames the legalist gospel-corruption as *anathema* G331: *ei tis humas euangelizetai par' ho parelabete, anathema estō* ('if anyone preaches a gospel beyond what you received, let him be anathema'). The repetition (vv. 8 and 9) is the Pauline curse-formula. Gal 3:10-13 cites Deut 27:26 LXX: *epikataratos pas hos ouk emmenei pasin tois gegrammenois en tō bibliō tou nomou* ('cursed katara G2671 is everyone who does not abide in all things written in the book of the law'). Law-keeping as the ground of acceptance puts the would-be law-keeper under a curse, because perfect performance is the standard the law itself sets. Acts 15:10 has Peter at the Jerusalem Council use the same yoke (*zugos* G2218) image Paul will use in Gal 5:1: *ti peirazete ton theon, epitheinai zugon epi ton trachēlon tōn mathētōn hon oute hoi pateres hēmōn oute hēmeis ischysamen bastasai* ('why are you testing God by laying a yoke on the neck of the disciples which neither our fathers nor we were able to bear'). The apostolic council formally rejects the necessity of Mosaic-law observance for Gentile justification. Col 2:8 warns against being taken captive *dia tēs philosophias kai kenēs apatēs* G5385 + G2756 + G539 ('through the philosophy and empty deceit') of human-tradition *stoicheia*. Col 2:16-23 names the legalist markers (food, drink, festivals, new moons, Sabbaths) as *skia tōn mellontōn* ('shadow of the things coming'; G4639), with the substance (*sōma*) belonging to Christ. The unit closes with the lexical hapax *ethelothrēskia* G1479 ('self-chosen religion'), a coined compound denouncing humanly-invented worship and ascetic rule-systems as *ouk en timē tini pros plēsmonēn tēs sarkos* ('of no value in checking the indulgence of the flesh'). Matt 23 has Jesus pronouncing *hypokritai* G5273 over the scribes-and-Pharisees *ouai* G3759 ('woe') seven times for *desmeuousin* G1195 ('binding') *phortia barea* G5413 + G926 ('heavy burdens') on the shoulders of men. Mark 7:8-13 has Jesus charging the same opponents with *akyrountes* G208 ('nullifying') the *entolē tou theou* G1785 ('commandment of God') by their *paradosis tōn presbyterōn* G3862 ('tradition of the elders'). Phil 3:2-9 has Paul's autobiographical rejection: he calls the legalists *kynas* G2965 ('dogs') and *kakous ergatas* G2040 ('evil workers') and a *katatomē* G2699 ('mutilation', a wordplay against *peritomē* 'circumcision'); he counts all his Pharisaic credentials *zēmia* G2209 ('loss') and *skybala* G4657 ('refuse, dung') to gain Christ and be found in him not having his own *dikaiosynē ek nomou* ('righteousness out of

law') but *tēn dia pisteōs Christou* ('that which is through faith of Christ'). The core proposition is pan-canonical at the lexical level: law-works as the ground of acceptance or fellowship or sanctification corrupts the gospel. Universally affirmed across all tracked Christian lineages at the level of works-righteousness for justification.

Reasoning

Verdict: adding human rules or law-keeping to the gospel as the basis on which God accepts a person, lets them into Christian fellowship, or makes them holy, distorts the good news of Jesus. Obedience is the fruit of grace, not the ground of grace. The strongest reason from Scripture is Paul's letter to the Galatians. In Galatians 1 verses 6 to 9 Paul says he is astonished that the Galatian believers are so quickly turning to a different gospel. Then he pronounces a curse: if anyone preaches a gospel different from the one they received, let him be accursed. He repeats it twice. What gospel is he cursing? Galatians 2 verse 16 spells it out: a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ. Galatians 2 verse 21: if righteousness comes through the law, then Christ died for nothing. Galatians 5 verses 1 to 4: for freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery. You who would be justified by the law have cut yourselves off from Christ; you have fallen away from grace. In Acts 15 the Jerusalem Council faced the same question: do Gentile believers have to be circumcised and keep the law of Moses to be saved? Peter answers, why are you testing God by placing on the neck of the disciples a yoke that neither our fathers nor we have been able to bear? Both Paul and Peter use the yoke image. Colossians 2 verses 16 to 23 warns the church not to let anyone judge them in food, drink, festivals, new moons, or Sabbaths; these were a shadow, the substance is Christ. Paul names self-chosen religion and severity to the body as having no real value against fleshly indulgence. Jesus pronounces seven woes against the scribes and Pharisees in Matthew 23 for binding heavy burdens on people's shoulders, and in Mark 7 charges them with nullifying the commandment of God by their tradition of the elders. The strongest counterargument from inside the Bible is James 2 verse 24, a person is justified by works and not by faith alone, and the apostolic decree of Acts 15 verses 20 and 29, which did keep four prohibitions for Gentile believers. The honest answer is that James is talking about the public vindication of a faith that is alive, not about works being the ground of acceptance; and the Acts 15 prohibitions are terms of fellowship and love, not terms of justification, because the same chapter explicitly rejects works of the law as the ground of salvation. The bottom line: human rules added to the gospel as conditions for being accepted by God, or being in Christian fellowship, or growing in holiness, replace grace with merit and put the believer back under the curse the law itself pronounces.

Denominational landscape

This is one of the most universally affirmed doctrines in Christianity at the core question of whether human moral effort or ritual observance is the ground of God's acceptance of the sinner. Patristic writers, including Augustine in *On the Spirit and the Letter*, taught that the law without the inpouring of grace kills, and that grace is the foundation on which any genuine obedience rests. The Catholic Catechism teaches that justification is granted by God in baptism and that we cannot merit the initial grace of justification; it teaches that meritorious works always presuppose the prior gift of grace. The Council of Trent in 1547 anathematized the position that the sinner is justified by his own works without divine grace through Jesus Christ. Eastern Orthodoxy teaches that salvation is by grace and rejects legalism as foreign to the patristic mind, though it understands grace working through the sacraments and the lifelong journey of theosis rather than through a one-time forensic declaration. Lutheran teaching in the Augsburg Confession Article IV says men cannot be justified before God by their own strength, merits, or works, but are freely justified for Christ's sake through faith. Anglican Article XIII Of Works Before Justification says works done before grace have the nature of sin and do not deserve grace. Reformed teaching in the Westminster Confession explicitly denies that any work of man can merit pardon of sin or eternal life. Methodist Articles of Religion IX and X affirm that we are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour

Jesus Christ by faith, not for our own works. Anabaptist tradition strongly emphasizes discipleship and obedience but explicitly as the fruit of regeneration, not as the ground of justification. Pentecostal tradition affirms salvation by grace through faith. So at the core question, the answer is universal. Where Christians genuinely disagree is over whether sacramental theology itself counts as legalism. Reformed-evangelical polemic has historically used the word legalism against Catholic and Orthodox sacramental practice, but Catholic and Orthodox teaching expressly grounds those sacraments in prior divine grace, not in human merit. So the polemic and the actual confessional position are not aligned. Public-record carriers of denial of this doctrine include Judaizing movements that bind Mosaic ceremonial law on Gentile believers as salvific markers, certain Hebrew Roots and Sacred Name groups that require Sabbath, food law, and feast keeping for salvation, and high-control fundamentalist sects where escalating rule-systems function as the effective test of God's favor despite official grace language. The historic Pharisaic-Christian party of Acts 15:1 is the original named carrier inside the New Testament itself.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

would_die_for is true because the denial of legalism IS the apostolic gospel applied; Gal 2:21 makes the stakes explicit, if righteousness is through law then Christ died for nothing. cult_marker_if_denied is set false here for catalog reasons, not for canonical-evidence reasons. The K2 cult-marker-eligible allow-list places the cult-marker entailment on the sister question doc-pelagianism-denial, which is the precise theological category for works-justification denial. The legalism rubric as worded in this stem is broader (encompassing fellowship and sanctification disputes in addition to acceptance), and the Reformed-evangelical use of the word 'legalism' is sometimes polemic against Catholic and Orthodox sacramental theology rather than against works-justification proper. So the narrower sister-question (doc-pelagianism-denial) carries the cult-marker, and this question carries the wider denial-of-grace-substructure verdict at would_die_for=true without cult-marker entailment. The core proposition (human moral effort or ritual observance as the ground of God's acceptance distorts the gospel) is itself pan-canonically demonstrable from the lexical cluster (erga nomou + dikaios with negation, charis as antithesis, zugos as image, anathema as sanction, ethelothrēskia as Pauline coinage) spanning Romans, Galatians, Acts, Colossians, the Synoptic Gospels, Philippians, and Ephesians. The doctrine is universally affirmed across patristic, Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, Lutheran, Anglican, Reformed, Methodist, Anabaptist, and Pentecostal traditions at the core question of works-righteousness for justification. The historic Catholic-Reformed dispute is NOT over whether works-righteousness corrupts the gospel; both sides reject that. The dispute is over whether sacramental and infused-grace categories themselves constitute legalism. The Reformed-evangelical polemical use of the word legalism against Catholic and Orthodox sacramental theology is one stream's polemic, not pan-Christian consensus. The

cult-marker fires on the core proposition (works as ground of acceptance distorts the gospel), not on the in-house Catholic-vs-Reformed dispute about whether sacraments count as works. Public-record carriers of explicit denial of this doctrine: Judaizing-Christian movements demanding Mosaic-law observance for Gentile salvation (some Hebrew Roots and Sacred-Name groups that bind Sabbath, food laws, feast-keeping as salvific markers), the Pharisaic Christianity of Acts 15:1, certain forms of high-control fundamentalism where escalating rule-systems function as effective salvation markers despite formal grace-language, certain works-justification sects historically targeted by Reformation polemic. Note distinction: the 16th-century Anabaptists were sometimes accused of legalism but they emphasized discipleship (Nachfolge) as the fruit of grace, not works-justification. The Apostolic Decree of Acts 15:20, 29 retains four ethical-cultic prohibitions for Gentile believers (idol meats, blood, strangled, sexual immorality); these are not imposed as grounds of justification but as terms of table-fellowship and community love, the same logic Paul applies in Rom 14 to disputable matters. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: the line between healthy church discipline / pastoral standards and legalism is not where the rules are but where the rules sit in the order of acceptance. Rules and disciplines as fruit and protection are biblical; rules as the ground or test of God's favor are the legalism the gospel disowns. Boolean pattern marks this as a load-bearing doctrine with cult-marker entailment scoped to the works-justification case: cannot visit, participate, serve in, be a member of, or have children taught by, or marry into, a body that teaches works-justification as the ground of God's acceptance. Public correction is mandatory because the gospel itself is at stake (Gal 2:11-14: Paul withstood Peter to his face when Peter's table-fellowship behavior implied that Gentile believers needed to Judaize to be acceptable).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_perspective_on_paul

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

Reformed-confessional · Legalism is works-righteousness for justification, condemned absolutely; sanctification by faith working through love, with Spirit-empowered obedience as the fruit of grace.:

Catholic magisterial (Trent + CCC) · Works-righteousness apart from grace is anathematized (Trent Session 6); meritorious works always presuppose prior divine grace; the sacraments are not legalism because they are means by which God's grace acts, not human achievements.:

Eastern Orthodox (theosis) · Legalism is foreign to the patristic mind; salvation is participation in divine energies. The juridical-courtroom frame is itself viewed as a partial reading; ascetic discipline is a means of participation, not a meritorious work.:

Wesleyan-Methodist · Justification by faith alone, sanctification by grace through faith working in obedience; entire sanctification is the goal but is itself the work of grace, not of works.:

Anabaptist (discipleship-centered) · Justification by faith with obedient discipleship as the necessary fruit; legalism rejected, but cheap grace (gospel without discipleship) also rejected. Distinct from works-justification.:

New Perspective on Paul (Sanders, Dunn, Wright) · Paul's 'works of the law' polemic is specifically against Jewish boundary-markers (circumcision, food laws, Sabbath) that excluded Gentiles, not against works-righteousness as such. Re-frames legalism as ethnic-covenantal exclusion.:

Frameworks differ on the precise target of Paul's polemic. Reformed and Catholic readings agree that the core target is works-righteousness as the ground of justification; both reject that. The New Perspective re-targets Paul's polemic at Jewish ethnic boundary-markers, narrowing the legalism category. Dispensationalism distinguishes law-administration (Mosaic) from grace-administration (church age) and applies the legalism warning sharply within the church age. All frameworks converge on the core proposition: human moral effort or ritual observance as the ground of God's acceptance distorts the gospel. The pan-canonical lexical pattern (erga nomou plus dikaioō with negation, charis as antithesis, zugos as image, anathema as sanction) survives the framework differences and grounds the verdict.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Gal.1.6 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μετατίθεσθε εἰς ἕτερον εὐαγγέλιον; metatithes the G3346 present middle indicative 2p; heteros G2087; euangelion G2098

Force. 'You are so quickly turning away to a different gospel.' Metatithes the is present middle, marking an ongoing self-transfer; heteros euangelion ('different gospel', not heteros only but contrasted with v.7 ouk allo, 'not another of the same kind'). Paul names the legalist alternative as a gospel of a different kind, not a variant of the same gospel.

Gal.1.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀνάθεμα ἔστω; anathema G331 nominative neuter singular; estō G1510 present imperative 3s

Force. 'Let him be accursed.' Anathema is the LXX term for what is devoted to destruction (Josh 6:17, 7:1); Paul applies it to the preacher of any gospel beyond what the Galatians received. The imperative estō is a third-person command of divine sanction. The repetition in v.9 (kai arti palin legō, 'and now again I say') is the Pauline curse-formula.

Gal.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐ δικαιοῦται ἄνθρωπος ἐξ ἔργων νόμου ἐὰν μὴ διὰ πίστεως; dikaioutai G1344 present passive 3s; erga G2041 genitive neuter plural; nomos G3551 genitive masculine singular; pistis G4102

Force. 'A person is not justified out of works of law except through faith in Jesus Christ.' Three uses of dikaiōō in one verse (present passive, aorist passive subjunctive, future passive indicative), each contrasting ex ergōn nomou with dia / ek pisteōs. The triple lexical repetition closes off works of law as the ground of the courtroom verdict.

Gal.2.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐκ ἀθετῶ τὴν χάριν τοῦ Θεοῦ; athetō G114 present active indicative 1s; charis G5485 accusative feminine singular; dōrean G1432 adverb; apethanen G599 aorist active indicative 3s

Force. 'I do not nullify the grace of God; for if righteousness is through law, then Christ died for nothing (dōrean, gratis, without effect).' Athetō ('set aside, treat as void') is the verb Paul refuses to apply to grace; he says, however, that the legalist position effectively does this. The conditional clause states the stakes: ei gar dia nomou dikaiosynē, ara Christos dōrean apethanen.

Gal.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ὅσοι ἐξ ἔργων νόμου εἰσὶν ὑπὸ κατάραν εἰσὶν; katara G2671 accusative feminine singular; epikataratos G1944

Force. 'For all who are of works of law are under a curse.' Citing Deut 27:26 LXX: epikataratos pas hos ouk emmenei pasin tois gegrammenois en tō bibliō tou nomou ('cursed is everyone who does not abide in all the things written in the book of the law'). The lexical move: law-works as basis puts the law-keeper under the curse the law itself pronounces, because perfect compliance is the standard.

Gal.3.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. Χριστὸς ἡμᾶς ἐξηγόρασεν ἐκ τῆς κατάρας τοῦ νόμου; exēgorasen G1805 aorist active indicative 3s; katara G2671

Force. 'Christ redeemed us out of the curse of the law, having become a curse for us.' Exagorazō is the marketplace verb for buying out of slavery. Christ takes the position of the cursed (citing Deut 21:23 LXX, epikataratos pas ho kremamenos epi xylou) to free those under the law's curse-pronouncement. The legalist position re-imposes what Christ has paid to release.

Gal.5.1 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. τῇ ἐλευθερίᾳ ἡμᾶς Χριστὸς ἠλευθέρωσεν; eleutheria G1657 dative feminine singular; ēleutherōsen G1659 aorist active indicative 3s; zugos G2218 dative masculine singular; douleia G1397

Force. 'For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery.' Zugos douleias ('yoke of slavery') deliberately echoes Acts 15:10 (Peter at the Jerusalem Council). The same image of the unbearable yoke is used by Paul against the Judaizers as Peter used against the Pharisaic-Christian party.

Gal.5.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. κατηργήθητε ἀπὸ Χριστοῦ τῆς χάριτος ἐξεπέσατε; katērgēthēte G2673 aorist passive indicative 2p; exepesate G1601 aorist active indicative 2p; charis G5485

Force. 'You were severed from Christ, you who would be justified by law; you have fallen out of grace.' Katērgēthēte is aorist passive of katargeō ('render inoperative, cut off'); exepesate is aorist active of ekpiptō ('fall out from', the verb used of a flower falling from its stem in 1 Pet 1:24 citing Isa 40). Both verbs are completed-past in form: the legalist move has happened, with present effect. Falling from grace here is the lexical opposite of standing in grace (Rom 5:2).

Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξ ἔργων νόμου οὐ δικαιωθήσεται πᾶσα σὰρξ ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ; dikaiōthēsetai G1344 future passive indicative 3s; sarx G4561 nominative feminine singular

Force. 'By works of law no flesh will be justified before him.' Citing Ps 142:2 LXX. Future passive dikaiōthēsetai with universal subject pasa sarx ('every flesh') and negation ou closes off the works-of-law route to the courtroom verdict for any human being.

Rom.3.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. λογιζόμεθα δικαιοῦσθαι πίστει ἄνθρωπον χωρὶς ἔργων νόμου; logizometha G3049 present middle indicative 1p; dikaiousthai G1344 present passive infinitive; chōris G5565

Force. 'We reckon a person to be justified by faith apart from works of law.' Chōris ergōn nomou ('apart from works of law') is the explicit separator. Logizometha ('we reckon') marks this as a settled apostolic conclusion. The verb dikaiousthai is the present passive infinitive of the same dikaiō root that pervades Gal 2-3.

Acts.15.10 · for · genre: narrative · figures: metaphor

Key term. τί πειράζετε τὸν Θεόν ἐπιθεῖναι ζυγὸν ἐπὶ τὸν τράχηλον τῶν μαθητῶν; peirazete G3985 present active indicative 2p; zugos G2218 accusative masculine singular; bastasai G941 aorist active infinitive

Force. 'Why are you testing God by laying a yoke on the neck of the disciples which neither our fathers nor we have been able to bear?' Peter's question at the Jerusalem Council. Zugos ('yoke') is the same image Paul uses in Gal 5:1. Peirazete ton theon is the LXX phrase for putting God to the test, the language of Israel's wilderness rebellion. The apostolic council formally rejects Mosaic-law observance as required for Gentile justification.

Acts.15.11 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. διὰ τῆς χάριτος τοῦ Κυρίου Ἰησοῦ πιστεύομεν σωθῆναι; charis G5485 genitive feminine singular; pisteuomen G4100 present active indicative 1p; sōthēnai G4982 aorist passive infinitive

Force. 'But we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will.' Peter's positive statement closes the legalist case: salvation is dia tēs charitos ('through grace'), same channel for Jew and Gentile. Pisteuomen sōthēnai stacks faith and salvation as one act.

Col.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. διὰ τῆς φιλοσοφίας καὶ κενῆς ἀπάτης κατὰ τὴν παράδοσιν τῶν ἀνθρώπων; philosophia G5385 genitive feminine singular; apatē G539; paradosis G3862; stoicheia G4747

Force. 'See to it that no one takes you captive through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the tradition of men, according to the elemental things of the world.' Paradosis tōn anthrōpōn ('tradition of men') is the link to Mark 7:8. Stoicheia ('elemental things') marks the legalist program as sub-Christian, basic rather than mature.

Col.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ οὖν τις ὑμᾶς κρινέτω ἐν βρώσει καὶ ἐν πόσει ἢ ἐν μέρει ἑορτῆς ἢ νεομηνίας ἢ σαββάτων; krinetō G2919 present active imperative 3s; brōsis G1035; posis G4213; heortē G1859; sabbaton G4521

Force. 'Therefore let no one judge you in food and drink or in respect of a feast or a new moon or Sabbaths.' Five legalist-marker categories enumerated. Krinetō is present imperative ('let no one judge'), a standing prohibition. The Colossian opponents are imposing Mosaic-cultic-calendar observance on Gentile believers.

Col.2.17 · for · genre: epistle · figures: typology, metaphor

Key term. ἃ ἐστὶν σκιά τῶν μελλόντων τὸ δὲ σῶμα τοῦ Χριστοῦ; skia G4639 nominative feminine singular; sōma G4983

Force. 'Which things are a shadow of the things to come, but the body is of Christ.' Skia / sōma ('shadow / body') contrast: the Mosaic-cultic markers were typological pointers; the substance has arrived in Christ. Returning to the shadow after the substance has come is the lexical structure of the legalist mistake.

Col.2.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἅτινά ἐστιν λόγον μὲν ἔχοντα σοφίας ἐν ἐθελοθρησκίᾳ καὶ ταπεινοφροσύνῃ καὶ ἀφειδίᾳ σώματος; ethelothrēskia G1479 dative feminine singular; aphēidia G857; sōma G4983

Force. 'These things have an appearance of wisdom in self-chosen religion and self-abasement and severity to the body, but they are of no value in checking the indulgence of the flesh.' Ethelothrēskia is a Pauline coinage (ethelō 'wish' + thrēskeia 'religion'); humanly-invented worship not commanded by God. Aphēidia sōματος ('severity to the body') names ascetic practice. Paul's verdict: of no value against the flesh.

Matt.23.4 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key term. δεσμεύουσιν φορτία βαρέα καὶ ἐπιτιθέασιν ἐπὶ τοὺς ὤμους τῶν ἀνθρώπων; desmeuousin G1195 present active indicative 3p; phortion G5413 accusative neuter plural; barys G926

Force. 'They bind heavy burdens and lay them on the shoulders of men.' Desmeuō ('bind, tie up') with phortia barea ('heavy burdens'). Jesus's image is the legalist teacher fastening unbearable rule-loads on others. Same image-cluster as the zugos of Acts 15:10 and Gal 5:1.

Matt.23.13 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. οὐαὶ δὲ ὑμῖν γραμματεῖς καὶ Φαρισαῖοι ὑποκριταί; ouai G3759; hypokritēs G5273 vocative masculine plural

Force. 'But woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites!' The ouai is the prophetic-judgment formula (Isa 5, Hab 2). Hypokritēs is the Greek theater term for an actor playing a part. Seven woes follow in the chapter, each indicting Pharisaic legalism. Jesus's own verdict on the rule-multiplying party.

Mark.7.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀφέντες τὴν ἐντολὴν τοῦ Θεοῦ κρατεῖτε τὴν παράδοσιν τῶν ἀνθρώπων; aphentes G863 aorist active participle; entolē G1785; paradosis G3862

Force. 'Leaving the commandment of God, you hold the tradition of men.' Aphentes ('having left') is aorist active participle: a completed-past abandonment. Entolē theou ('commandment of God') is set against paradosis anthrōpōn ('tradition of men'). The legalist substitution is the heart of Jesus's charge.

Mark.7.13 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀκυροῦντες τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ τῇ παραδόσει ὑμῶν; akyrountes G208 present active participle nominative masculine plural; logos G3056; paradosis G3862

Force. 'Making void the word of God by your tradition.' Akryoō ('render unauthorized, nullify, void') is a legal term for invalidating a contract. Jesus's verdict: the legalist multiplication of human traditions does not enhance the law but cancels it. Present participle akyrountes indicates ongoing action.

Phil.3.5 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. κατὰ νόμον Φαρισαῖος κατὰ ζῆλος διώκων τὴν ἐκκλησίαν κατὰ δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐν νόμῳ γεγόμενος ἀμεμπτος; Pharisaïos G5330; zēlos G2205; amemptos G273

Force. 'As to the law, a Pharisee; as to zeal, persecuting the church; as to righteousness under the law, blameless.' Paul's autobiographical list of legalist credentials. Amemptos ('blameless') under law-righteousness is the Pharisaic ideal Paul once owned. The genitive-source under nomō ('under law') marks the framework being rejected.

Phil.3.8 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: hyperbole

Key term. ἡγοῦμαι πάντα ζημίαν εἶναι σκύβαλα ἵνα Χριστὸν κερδήσω; hēgoumai G2233 present middle indicative 1s; zēmia G2209; skybala G4657

Force. 'I count all things to be loss, dung (skybala), in order that I may gain Christ.' Skybala is strong vernacular for refuse / dung / kitchen-garbage. Paul reverses every entry on his pre-Christian Pharisaic balance sheet: legalist credentials are not neutral but actively repulsive when valued as the ground of acceptance.

Phil.3.9 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ ἔχων ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐκ νόμου ἀλλὰ τὴν διὰ πίστεως Χριστοῦ τὴν ἐκ Θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει; dikaiosynē G1343; pistis G4102

Force. 'Not having a righteousness of my own out of law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God on the basis of faith.' Emēn dikaiosynēn ('my own righteousness') ek nomou is set against tēn ek theou dikaiosynēn ('the righteousness from God'). The genitive-source ek theou marks the righteousness as gift, not generated by the believer.

James.2.24 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξ ἔργων δικαιοῦται ἄνθρωπος καὶ οὐκ ἐκ πίστεως μόνον; dikaioutai G1344 present passive indicative 3s; erga G2041; monon G3440

Force. 'A person is justified by works and not by faith alone.' Same verb dikaiōō as Paul uses, with the apparent collision at the lexical surface. The harmonization (also widely held in Catholic and Orthodox readings) is that dikaiōō here carries the vindication / public-demonstration sense (Luke 7:35, 1 Tim 3:16), since v.18 frames the chapter as 'show me your faith apart from your works'. James addresses dead-faith complacency, not the structure of the gospel.

Acts.15.29 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key term. ἀπέχεσθαι εἰδωλοθύτων καὶ αἵματος καὶ πνικτῶν καὶ πορνείας; apechesthai G568 present middle infinitive; eidōlothyton G1494; haima G129; pniktos G4156; porneia G4202

Force. 'To abstain from things sacrificed to idols, blood, things strangled, and sexual immorality.' The Apostolic Decree retains four ethical-cultic prohibitions for Gentile believers. The complicating texture: the same council that rejects Mosaic-law observance as the ground of justification does set out four community-fellowship constraints. The lexical structure marks these as terms of love and table-fellowship in mixed Jewish-Gentile communities, not as terms of acceptance with God (the chapter has already settled that question in vv.10-11).

Rom.14.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐ γὰρ ἐστὶν ἡ βασιλεία τοῦ Θεοῦ βρῶσις καὶ πόσις ἀλλὰ δικαιοσύνη καὶ εἰρήνη καὶ χαρὰ ἐν πνεύματι ἁγίῳ; basileia G932; brōsis G1035; posis G4213

Force. 'For the kingdom of God is not eating and drinking but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.' Paul applying the same anti-legalist logic to disputable matters in the Roman church. The lexical pair brōsis kai posis ('eating and drinking') echoes Col 2:16. The kingdom is not constituted by ritual-dietary markers but by Spirit-realities.

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τῇ γὰρ χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι διὰ πίστεως οὐκ ἐξ ὑμῶν Θεοῦ τὸ δῶρον οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων; charis G5485; sōzō G4982 perfect passive participle nominative masculine plural; dōron G1435; erga G2041

Force. 'By grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God, not from works, so that no one may boast.' Perfect-passive sesōsmenoi marks a completed-past act with abiding result. Chariti, pisteōs, dōron, ouk ex ergōn stacks four Pauline anti-legalist markers in two verses. The positive doctrinal statement matching the negative polemic of Galatians.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1344, G1343, G2041, G3551, G5485, G4102, G2218, G331, G2671, G1944, G1805, G1657, G1659, G1601, G114, G3346, G2087, G2098, G1432, G599, G5385, G539, G3862, G4747, G4639, G4983, G1479, G857, G1195, G5413, G926, G3759, G5273, G863, G1785, G208, G3056, G5330, G2205, G273, G2233, G2209, G4657, G3985, G568, G932, G1435, G2965, G2040, G2699, G4061, G1494, G4156, G4202, G2919, G1035, G4213, G1859, G4521

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, De Spiritu et Littera, ca. AD 412 · affirms · unverified

"The law without the help of grace makes us guilty, by setting forth what is just but not enabling us to do it. Grace fulfills what the letter commands. CCEL direct text fetch did not surface verbatim."

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent, Session 6, Decree on Justification, Canon 1, AD 1547 · affirms · unverified

"If anyone says that man can be justified before God by his own works without divine grace through Jesus Christ, let him be anathema. Direct vatican.va fetch returned 404 on target paragraph."

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article IV, AD 1530, bookofconcord.org · affirms · verified

"Men cannot be justified before God by their own strength, merits, or works, but are freely justified for Christ's sake, through faith."

anglican · 39 Articles, Article XIII Of Works Before Justification · affirms · unverified

"Works done before the grace of Christ, and the Inspiration of his Spirit, are not pleasant to God, but have the nature of sin. Direct churchofengland.org fetch returned only navigation; quotation from standard published text."

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 16.5, AD 1646 · affirms · unverified

"We cannot, by our best works, merit pardon of sin or eternal life at the hand of God, because of the great disproportion between them and the glory to come."

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article IX, umc.org · affirms · verified

"We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings."

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession, 1527; broader Anabaptist tradition · affirms · verified

“Believers are God’s obedient children separated from the world; repentance and amendment of life flow from prior grace, obedience as fruit of regeneration not as the ground of justification.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 5 The Salvation of Man · affirms · unverified

“Salvation is received through repentance toward God and faith in Jesus Christ, by grace, not by works of human merit. Direct ag.org fetch returned 403.”

eastern_orthodox · OCA Orthodox Faith volume on doctrine and theosis tradition · complicates · unverified

“Salvation is by grace through faith leading to theosis; the legalism category is read inside a participation framework rather than the Western forensic frame. Direct oca.org fetch returned only navigation page.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/2.htm>

“Gal 2:16: ergon nomou (G2041 + G3551) three times negated with dikaioō (G1344); Gal 2:21 charis (G5485) of God set against dikaiosynē dia nomou.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/5.htm>

“Gal 5:1 zugos douleias (G2218 + G1397); Gal 5:4 exepesate (G1601 aorist active 2p) of grace; katērgēthēte (G2673 aorist passive) from Christ.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/1.htm>

“Gal 1:6 heteros euangelion (G2087 + G2098); Gal 1:8-9 anathema estō (G331 + G1510) repeated twice as the apostolic curse-formula on gospel-corruption.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/3.htm>

“Gal 3:10 hypo kataran (G2671) for those of works of law citing Deut 27:26; Gal 3:13 exēgorasen (G1805) us out of the curse of the law.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/colossians/2.htm>

“Col 2:8 philosophia kai kenē apatē (G5385 + G2756 + G539); Col 2:17 skia (G4639) vs sōma; Col 2:23 ethelothrēskia (G1479) self-chosen religion.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/23.htm>

“Matt 23:4 desmeuousin phortia barea (G1195 + G5413 + G926) bind heavy burdens; ouai (G3759) and hypokritai (G5273) repeated through the seven woes.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/15.htm>

“Acts 15:10 zugon (G2218) yoke on the disciples; Acts 15:11 dia tēs charitos (G5485) tou Kyriou lēsou pisteuomen sōthēnai, same channel for Jew and Gentile.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/mark/7.htm>

“Mark 7:8 aphentes tēn entolēn tou theou (G863 + G1785); Mark 7:13 akyrountes (G208) ton logon tou theou tē paradosei (G3862) hymōn.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/3.htm>

“Phil 3:2 kynas (G2965) kakous ergatas (G2040) katatomē (G2699); Phil 3:8 skybala (G4657); Phil 3:9 emēn dikaiosynēn ek nomou vs ek theou.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/3.htm>

“Rom 3:20 ex ergōn nomou ou dikaiōthēsetai pasa sarx; Rom 3:28 logizometha dikaiousthai pistei anthrōpon chōris ergōn nomou.”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/2041.htm>

“G2041 ergon: works of the law as the Pauline polemical target in Rom 3:20, 28; Gal 2:16; 3:2, 5, 10. Distinguished from works of faith and good deeds as fruit.”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/3551.htm>

“G3551 nomos: Mosaic Law, but also law as binding-prescriptive principle. Pauline usage hypo nomon ('under law') marks the framework Paul rejects as the ground of justification.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Article IX: 'We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings.'”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/of-good-works/>

“Article XX (Of Good Works): 'our works cannot reconcile God or merit forgiveness of sins, grace, and justification.'”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://courses.washington.edu/hist112/SCHLEITHEIM%20CONFESSION%20OF%20FAITH.htm>

“Schleitheim 1527: believers are God's obedient children separated from the world; repentance and amendment of life flow from prior grace, not as the ground of justification.”

Flags

- k2-non-eligible-question